

Feminist Make-Believe

A science fiction tracking a girl's journey falls apart under its own didactic weight

By Brinda Bose



ESCAPE
by MANJULA
PADMANABHAN
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I must have missed a bit of advance-literary news, so I came to *Escape* with no idea that this was Manjula Padmanabhan's first throw at a full-length (rather too full...) science fiction for adults. Too late to escape, you might say. In fact, a grimly-entertaining, futuristic, (sort of) feminist novel could well be exactly what I needed to convert myself into a sci-fi junkie overnight. However, I must admit that Padmanabhan's confident speculations on her presumed readership have turned me mulish: "...serious readers over the age of 40 will find it hard to engage with it, because the older generation of Indian readers tend to comprise people who think of reading as a sober activity—perhaps because it used to be a medium for scholarship and study rather than for personal entertainment...."

Given that I belong to that fellowship of the over-40 geriatrics she is referring to, and am doubly sinning as I have read literature as "a medium of scholarship" (whatever that might mean), am I to understand that I am incapable,

therefore, of reading novels for pleasure, and have never done so, even the Enid Blytons and the Louisa May Alcotts one cuts one's reading teeth on through endless schoolday afternoons? The mind boggles, as Wodehouse/Wooster would have intoned.

In other words, methinks the lady doth protest too much. Padmanabhan also says that though she has a sequel simmering in the pipeline (she coyly discloses that she knows "what will happen, let's put it that way"), she will only write it if this venture does well. (At the box office? By critical acclaim? She does not clarify).

The fundamental premise of the novel is feminist, though I am not sure if the author would like it to be so slotted. Triggered by persistent reports of female infanticide and sliding female sex ratio figures in our part of the world, Padmanabhan envisages another, beyond ours in time and space, in which there is but one female remaining. She is Meiji, a young girl who is being brought up on hormone-suppressants at an Estate in this imagined country (where they eat parathas) by a set of three Uncles, known as Eldest, Middle and Youngest. They have so far succeeded in keeping her hidden from the probing gaze of the despotic Generals and their clone-brothers who rule this world in a male bubble—even going so far as to supply her with a prosthetic penis—but now they take the painful decision to send her away to another planet where, they hope, the female species still exists. *Escape* tracks the journey Meiji reluctantly undertakes in the care of Youngest, out of the Estate and into the great unknown. Youngest is deliciously torn between avuncular love and concern, and a forbidden physical desire, rising and cresting through Meiji's frangible feminising process that he must guide.

Somewhere, however, despite Youngest, Meiji and the fraught, ferocious focus of the novel, it fails to retain its grip—simply for need of pruning and sprucing. What is absorbing to start with, the rendition of a contradistinctive reality, begins to pall in its repetitiveness because the plot can't carry the weight of its copiousness. Sharply edited, it would have made a far greater impact than it finally does. But read it, and spare a thought for Meiji, our future. ■



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